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Valla Grammaticus, Agostino Steuco, and the Donation of Constantine

Ronald K. Delph

Recent studies dealing with Lorenzo Valla's treatise on the Donation of Constantine have provided us with a profound understanding of the revolutionary nature of this work. Scholars have rightly seen the *De falso credita et ementita Constantini donatione* (1440) as one of Valla's earliest attempts to apply the principles of Quintilian's rhetoric to textual scholarship. Valla followed Quintilian both in the structure of his arguments against the authenticity of the actions described in the Donation, as well as in the critical tools that he employed while attacking the language found in the text itself.¹ In his use of philology and grammar as analytical tools and in his perception that historical development was reflected by changes in linguistic style and word meaning, Valla closely followed Quintilian.²

¹ For the influence of Quintilian on Valla see Salvatore I. Camporeale, *Lorenzo Valla: umanesimo e teologia* (Florence, 1972), 36-164, 230, and *idem*, "Lorenzo Valla e il *De falso credita donatione*," *Memorie domenicane*, n.s., 19 (1988), 191-293; also Wolfram Setz, *Lorenzo Vallas Schrift gegen die Konstantinische Schenkung* (Tübingen, 1975), 43-51; Vincenzo De Caprio, "Retorica e ideologia nella Declamatio di Lorenzo Valla sulla donazione di Costantino," *Paragone*, 338 (1978), 36-56; and Carlo Ginzburg's preface to Lorenzo Valla, *La Donation de Constantin*, tr. Jean-Baptiste Giard (Paris, 1993), ix-xxi. Citations of Valla's treatise are from Lorenzo Valla, *De falso credita et ementita Constantini donatione*, ed. Wolfram Setz, *Monumenta Germaniae Historica, Quellen zur Geistesgeschichte des Mittelalters*, X (Weimar, 1976), 55-176.

² Camporeale, *Lorenzo Valla*, 36-108, and *idem*, "Valla e il *De falso credita donatione*," 199-200, 238-44. For Valla's philology in general, see David Marsh, "Grammar, Method, and Polemic in Lorenzo Valla's *Elegantiae*," *Rinascimento*, 19 (1979), 91-116. There has been much recent debate concerning Valla as a "language philosopher," in which scholars have assessed Valla's understanding of the relationship between language and culture, *verbum et res*. For the arguments, see Richard Waswo, *Language and Meaning in the Renaissance* (Princeton, 1987); and his "Motives of Misreading," in *Renaissance Essays II*, ed. William J. Connell (Rochester, 1993), 101-9; Maristella Lorch, "Lorenzo Valla," in *Renaissance Humanism: Foundations, Forms and Legacy*, ed. Albert Rabil, 3

The scholarly methodology employed in this work helped Valla lay the foundations for his radical reorientation of the *ars rhetorica* in which he established philology, grammar, and historical perspective as essential components of his textual scholarship. Using the principles of rhetoric that Quintilian laid out in his *Institutio oratoria*, Valla sought to broaden the scope of humanist critical activity and present humanists with several key elements with which to engage in linguistic and textual studies.³ The significance of what he had accomplished was clear to the Roman humanist. In December 1443 he boasted to Giovanni Aurispa that “I have never written anything more oratorical than my oration” on the Donation of Constantine.⁴ Valla here expressed his belief that his treatise had succeeded in incorporating the strictures and theories espoused in Quintilian’s work into a viable humanist program of textual and linguistic scholarship.

Valla’s *De Constantini donatione* is of undeniable importance for understanding his early development as a humanist textual critic and language philosopher. But what has escaped most historians is the oration’s problem of methodology, and the deficiencies of philology and grammar as tools of textual criticism in this work. To put it bluntly, scholars, while focusing on the promising innovations found there, have consistently ignored what by later standards would be considered the serious methodological flaws in Valla’s treatise. The Vallian *ars rhetorica* as articulated in this work by no means presented a model from which later humanists would derive the foundations of modern textual criticism. By the late fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries, textual scholars had shown the inadequacies of the methodology Valla employed in this treatise. In fact the best humanist scholars of the period approached the task of textual criticism and manuscript emendation using procedures that were essentially at odds with the philological, grammatical critique used in this work.⁵

While most modern historians have overlooked the scholarly shortcomings of Valla’s treatise, the sixteenth century produced one critic who raised serious questions about the scholarship underlying the critique of the Donation. Twice in his lifetime, the Italian humanist Agostino Steuco (1497-1548)

vols. (Philadelphia, 1988), I, 332-49; and John Monfasani, “Was Lorenzo Valla an Ordinary Language Philosopher?” in *Renaissance Essays II*, ed. Connell, 86-100.

³ See Camporeale, *Lorenzo Valla, passim*; and Donald R. Kelley, *Foundations of Modern Historical Scholarship* (New York, 1970), 21-46.

⁴ Quoted by Ginzburg in Valla, *La Donation de Constantin*, x. On Valla’s treatise as an oration, see *idem*, ix-xxi; and De Caprio, “Retorica e ideologia,” 41-42.

⁵ My thoughts here are shaped by Anthony Grafton, *Joseph Scaliger: A Study in the History of Classical Scholarship*, Vols. I and II (Oxford, 1983-93); *idem*, “Quattrocento Humanism and Classical Scholarship,” in *Renaissance Humanism*, ed. Rabil, III, 23-65; and by John D’Amico, *Theory and Practice in Renaissance Textual Criticism. Beatus Rhenanus Between Conjecture and History* (Berkeley, 1988).

published significant replies to Valla. First in his *Pro religione christiana adversus Lutheranos* (1530), and then in his *Contra Laurentium Vallam de falso donatione Constantini libri duo* (1547), Steuco raised substantial objections to a number of Valla's philological, grammatical, and historical arguments against the authenticity of the edict.⁶

In each treatise Steuco's textual scholarship on the Donation formed part of a larger effort on his part to defend the cultic practices, institutions, and hierarchy of the late medieval church against the reformers. As he made clear in both works, he believed that Valla's attacks upon the papacy and Donation put him in league with Luther and Erasmus in undermining respect for the papacy in the early sixteenth century. While these two works recently have proved to be of great interest to historians of religion and reform in sixteenth-century Italy, I shall confine the present analysis to Steuco's scholarship on the Donation.

Taking direct aim at Valla's philological and grammatical analysis of the language of the Donation, Steuco repeatedly characterized Valla as being nothing more than a "grammarian."⁷ Valla had blundered badly in his analysis, Steuco pointed out, by ignoring the first step of good textual criticism. He failed to establish the *vera lectio* or true reading of the text by consulting the best manuscripts before he began his scholarly critique.⁸ Instead, Valla had based his philological observations and historical arguments on a truncated, corrupted recension of the text as it appeared in Gratian's *Decretum*.⁹ Because he had not established the *vera lectio*, Valla made numerous errors in his analysis of the Donation.

⁶ On Steuco see Theobald Freudenberger, *Augustinus Steuchus aus Gubbio, Augustinerchorherr und päpstlicher Bibliothekar (1497-1548)* (Münster in Westfalen, 1935); Mariano Crociata, *Umanesimo e teologia in Agostino Steuco. Neoplatonismo e teologia della creazione nel "De perenni philosophia"* (Rome, 1987); and Maria Muccillo, "La 'prisca theologia' nel 'De perenni philosophia' di Agostino Steuco," *Rinascimento*, 28 (1988), 41-111. Steuco's *Adversus Lutheranos* has been analyzed by Silvana Seidel Menchi in her *Erasmus in Italia 1520-1580* (Turin, 1987), 41-68, while these two treatises are explored in a broader religious and cultural context in my "From Venetian Visitor to Curial Humanist: The Development of Agostino Steuco's 'Counter'-Reformation Thought," *Renaissance Quarterly*, 47 (1994), 102-39.

⁷ Steuco, *Adversus Lutheranos*, f. 12^v, labelled Valla a "vir simplicissimus grammaticus"; while in the *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, he raged against Valla as an "iniquissimus ... impudens grammaticus," (f. 217^v); and rejected Valla's arguments because "... more grammaticulorum, destomachatur ..." (f. 218^v). See also ff. 211^v, 220^r, 221^r.

⁸ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 216^r, "Totumque hoc calumniarum genus contra donationem cognoscetur esse inane, propterea quod profert verba ex donatione, ut apud Canonistas haberentur, nec curavit, aviditate calumniandi proventus, proferre ex Graecis, aut vetustis Latinis codicibus verba ista donationis." At f. 216^v he wrote, "Scire quoque operae pretium est verba donationis a Laurentio proferri non adhibitis variis exemplaribus, sed quo calumniis suis esset locus, dumtaxat, ut legerat apud Gratianum."

⁹ For the Donation as it appears in Gratian, consult the *Corpus iuris canonici, pars prior Decretum magistri Gratiani*, ed. Aemilius Ludwig Richter (Leipzig, 1879). The Donation is at *distinctio* XCVI, ch. 14, 342-45. Properly speaking, the document is referred to as the *Constitutum Constantini*. The text as it appeared in Gratian's *Decretum* began in

Steuco's ongoing confrontation with Valla was based on the manuscript evidence that he drew from a number of Greek and Latin codices he had discovered, all of which contained the text of the Donation.¹⁰ As he pointed out, the reading preserved in several of these texts deviated significantly from the text Valla used. Moreover, in many instances, these texts supplied variants for the "linguistic barbarisms" against which Valla had raged. And more than once these manuscripts...a number of which were clearly older than the text from which Valla worked...revealed that Valla had poured out his philological and grammatical bile over what were corruptions in his text. Furthermore, Valla's methodology led him to ignore the complex manuscript tradition of the *Donatio*. As Steuco pointed out, this textual tradition raised a number of substantial questions concerning the history and reception of the Donation that Valla's scholarship in no way addressed. Through an increasingly sophisticated analysis of his manuscripts, Steuco sought vigorously to expose the serious methodological flaws that ran through the *De Constantini donatione*.

In this essay, I propose to analyze briefly the method employed by Steuco when he used these manuscripts in his attacks against Valla. By examining Steuco's textual scholarship and his criticisms of Valla, we can follow the confrontation between the process of textual criticism Valla employed in his treatise and that used by one of the better textual scholars of the early sixteenth century. While examining Steuco's critique of Valla's methodology, we can also glimpse the change in humanist textual scholarship that developed in the century that elapsed between Valla and Steuco. This study will give us a greater appreciation for Valla's weaknesses as well as his strengths as a textual scholar in his *De Constantini donatione*. At the same time, our investigation will provide a sense of balance to the often uncritical reception that the Vallian *ars rhetorica* has received in recent scholarship. Scholars should be aware...as Steuco made evident to his contemporaries...that Valla's treatise revealed the striking limitations of earlier Renaissance textual criticism.

the middle of the decree with the so-called *Donatio*. The editor who inserted the decree into the *Decretum* excerpted only part of the text from the longer, older recension preserved in the Pseudo-Isidorean decretals. For Valla's use of the edict as it appeared in Gratian, see Setz, *Lorenzo Vallas Schrift*, 39-41. For an analysis of the entire decree and its insertion into Gratian, consult Christopher Coleman, *Constantine the Great and Christianity* (New York, 1914), 176-78. On the antiquity of the Pseudo-Isidorean recension, see Horst Fuhrmann, *Einfluss und Verbreitung pseudoisidorischen Fälschungen, Schriften des Monumenta Germaniae Historica*, XXIV (Stuttgart, 1972), pt. II, 354-89; also his critical edition of the Donation in *Constitutum Constantini, Fontes iuris Germanici antiqui in usum scholarum ex Monumentis Germaniae Historicis separatim editi*, X (Hanover, 1968), 56-98, citations here by line number.

¹⁰ I use the term *Donatio* in this essay to specify the text of the decree, and the terms Donation, edict, decree, and *Constitutum Constantini* to refer in a more general sense to the Donation of Constantine.

In 1528 while living at the monastery of Sant' Antonio di Castello in Venice, Steuco discovered in the monastery's library a manuscript containing a Greek text of the Donation.¹¹ He quickly recognized that this Greek manuscript offered a reading which differed in a number of places from the Latin recension preserved in Gratian's *Decretum*. Even accounting for the vagaries of translation from Latin into Greek, the Greek text also presented a number of variants from Gratian's Latin text. Aware of the importance of his new find, Steuco soon published this Greek text along with a Latin translation in his *Adversus Lutheranos*.¹²

Steuco's publication and handling of this Greek text were designed to expose the inadequacies of the Vallian *ars rhetorica* as the basis for textual criticism in the *De Constantini donatione*. His was a calculated move, aimed in part at a new generation of Italian textual scholars who had been inspired by the scholarly methods of the late Quattrocento Florentine humanist, Angelo Poliziano (1454-94).¹³

Poliziano had revolutionized humanist textual criticism by designing effective procedures for evaluating and using manuscript evidence to emend corrupted texts. He insisted that textual scholarship be rooted in the careful collation of manuscripts. This readily enabled him to identify interpolations and restore lacunae in texts based on the authority of other uncorrupted manuscripts. Poliziano also showed how the scholar could use the variants and corruptions that emerged from manuscript collation to propose corrected

¹¹ Steuco belonged to the order of Augustinian Canons of the Congregation of San Salvatore, and the monastery of Sant' Antonio in Venice was a member of this Congregation. On this order see Giuseppe Mozzagrungno, *Narratio rerum gestarum canonicorum regularium* (Venice, 1622). For the monastery and library of Sant' Antonio, consult Antonio Foscari and Manfredo Tafuri, "Sebastiano da Lugano, i Grimani e Jacopo Sansovino. Artisti e committenti nella chiesa di Sant'Antonio di Castello," *Arte veneta*, 36 (1982), 100-23; Theobald Freudenberger, "Die Bibliothek des Kardinals Domenico Grimani," *Historisches Jahrbuch*, 56 (1936), 15-45; and Giovanni Mercati, *Codici Latini Pico Grimani Pio, Studi e testi*, LXXV (Vatican City, 1938), 26-28. For Steuco in Venice, see Freudenberger, *Augustinus Steuchus*, 42-71; and Delph, "Steuco's 'Counter'-Reformation Thought," 104-24.

¹² Steuco, *Adversus Lutheranos*, ff. 13^v-14^r. The text also appears in *Patrologiae cursus completus, series graeca*, ed. J.-P. Migne (Paris, 1857-1912), CIV, 1078-83 (hereafter cited as *PG*). Steuco was not the first humanist to encounter this Greek text, but he was the first to publish and use it in a systematic scholarly fashion against Valla. For earlier humanists who had encountered Greek texts of the Donation, see Carlo Vecce, "Antonio Galateo e la difesa della donazione di Costantino," *Aevum*, 59 (1985), 353-60; Setz, *Lorenzo Vallas Schrift*, 110-23; Giovanni Antonazzi, "Lorenzo Valla e la donazione di Costantino nel secolo XV con un testo inedito di Antonio Cortese," *Rivista di storia della Chiesa in Italia*, 4 (1950), 186-234, and *idem*, *Lorenzo Valla e la polemica sulla Donazione di Costantino* (Rome, 1985).

¹³ The following discussion is based on Grafton, *Joseph Scaliger*, I, 10-43, and "Quattrocento Humanism," 23-54; D'Amico, *Beatus Rhenanus*, 1-27; and Carlo Dionisotti, "Calderini, Poliziano e altri," *Italia medioevale e umanistica*, 11 (1968), 151-79.

readings for a text. He particularly stressed paleographical analysis as the key to recovering the true reading of a corrupt text. This insistence on manuscript-based emendation, or *emendatio ope codicum*, helped eliminate the guesswork and arbitrary nature of textual criticism that was characteristic of scholarship before Poliziano.¹⁴

Other Quattrocento Italian humanists also made substantial contributions to the field of manuscript-based textual retrieval, although none was the equal of Poliziano. Filippo Beroaldo the Elder (1453-1505), while prone to rely upon conjecture to improve upon a manuscript reading, nevertheless made substantial use of manuscript evidence in his annotations on classical texts. Moreover, Beroaldo successfully demonstrated that the writings of ancient Greek and Latin historians could be used to annotate obscure passages or restore corrupted phrases in problematic classical authors. Baptista Guarino (1435-1505) likewise made good use of manuscript evidence in emending texts, and like Beroaldo, he too skillfully used the collateral works of ancient authors to annotate difficult passages and restore corrupted reading in texts.

The Venetian humanist Ermolao Barbaro (1453-92) perhaps came closer than any other contemporary scholar in his ability to follow Poliziano's techniques and standards in textual emendation. He popularized *emendatio ope codicum* among Venetian humanists, earning for the new methodology wide acceptance in Venetian humanist circles. While this scholarly tradition waned somewhat after the death of its major proponents Poliziano and Barbaro, it was revived in Italy by the second decade of the 1500s. Following the lead of these men, Italian editors and textual scholars recognized that a critical edition and reliable exegesis began with the careful collation of the best manuscript sources.¹⁵

¹⁴ As he showed in his two versions of annotations on the Greek New Testament, Valla was quite capable of manuscript-based emendation. Grafton has noted, however, that Poliziano far surpassed Valla in standardizing procedures for manuscript citation and codicology. More importantly, Valla never succeeded in establishing a school of followers to keep his methodology alive. It was Poliziano...not Valla...who exercised a dominant influence among late fifteenth and early sixteenth century Italian textual critics. See Grafton, *Joseph Scaliger*, I, 10-70; and *idem*, "Quattrocento Humanism," 22-25. For Valla's work on the New Testament, consult Camporeale, *Lorenzo Valla*, 278-370; and Jerry Bentley, *Humanists and Holy Writ* (Princeton, 1983), 32-69.

¹⁵ On Beroaldo and Guarino see Vincenzo Fera, "Polemiche filologiche intorno allo Svetonio del Beroaldo," in *The Uses of Greek and Latin*, ed. A. C. Dionisotti (London, 1988), 71-87; useful too on Beroaldo is Grafton, "Quattrocento Humanism," 26-30. On Barbaro, see Vittore Branca, "Ermolao Barbaro and Late Quattrocento Venetian Humanism," in *Renaissance Venice*, ed. J. R. Hale (Totowa, N.J., 1973), 218-43; *idem*, "Ermolao Barbaro e l'umanesimo veneziano," *Umanesimo europeo e umanesimo veneziano*, ed. Vittore Branca (Venice, 1963), 193-212; Dionisotti, "Calderini, Poliziano e altri," 160-63; and D'Amico, *Beatus Rhenanus*, 22-23, 84-90.

Steuco's annotations on the Old Testament and on classical and historical texts reveal that he was a direct heir to this manuscript-based approach to textual scholarship.¹⁶ It was Valla's deficiency in this respect that he punctuated with his publication of a variant Greek text of the Donation in 1530.

Steuco emphasized the lack of manuscript sources in Valla's treatise by closely adhering to Poliziano's own procedures for handling manuscripts as he presented his Greek text. These procedures...authenticating, identifying and giving the location of manuscript sources...were characteristic of his scholarship, and he employed them again in his *Contra Laurentium Vallam*. This is extremely significant for our analysis because Steuco was following the best scholarly techniques developed in the Renaissance for presenting and handling manuscripts.¹⁷ This ensured that other scholars could not ignore the evidence that he cited in opposition to Valla. Also, by drawing scholarly attention to the existence of older manuscripts that preserved variant texts, Steuco intended to undermine the critical procedure of the Vallian *ars rhetorica* as well as the historical and linguistic conclusions based upon this methodology. These procedures laid the foundation for Steuco's attack on Valla's textual criticism, and so we must briefly examine the methodology Steuco employed when he introduced his newly discovered manuscript to the scholarly world.

Poliziano had insisted that scholars discuss the origins of their manuscripts as a hedge against forgeries, and to help authenticate a manuscript's value as a textual authority.¹⁸ To this end, Steuco meticulously discussed the provenance of his Greek text, drawing upon evidence provided by the Latin scribe who had copied the document. He told his reader:

Indeed I shall produce the Decree of Constantine himself, written in Greek, copied out of a book which was in the palace library in

¹⁶ See for example, his *De nomine urbis suae Eugubium* (1540), in the *Opera omnia*, III, ff. 208^r-209^r; and his *Veteris testamenti ad Hebraicam veritatem recognitio* (1529), in *ibid.*, I, ff. 83^r-180^r. Steuco identified himself with Barbaro's scholarship in his *An vulgata editio sit Divi Hieronymi*, *ibid.*, I, f. 246^r, where he praised the "eruditissimo Hermolao" and defended his work. Steuco's student Leonardo Malaspina (d. 1571), who was in Rome in the 1550s and 1560s, frequently corresponded with one of Poliziano's well known followers in Florence, Pier Vettori (1499-1585). In the preface to his annotations on Cicero's letters, published in *Epistolae Marci Tullii Ciceronis ad Atticum, Brutum et Q. Fratrem*, (Venice, 1564), sig. Bi^r-Ciiii^v, Malaspina articulated a virtual manifesto of the principles of *emendatio ope codicum*. On Malaspina see Prospero Cavalieri, *Biblioteca compendiosa degli uomini illustri della congregazione de' canonici regolari del SS. Salvatore Lateranesi* (Velletri, 1836), 5-13; and Pio Paschini, "Un ellenista del Cinquecento: Nicolo Majorano," in *Cinquecento romano e Riforma cattolica*, ed. Pio Paschini (Rome, 1958), 219-36. For Vettori see Grafton, *Joseph Scaliger*, I, 53-70; and D'Amico, *Beatus Rhenanus*, 27.

¹⁷ Cf. Grafton, *Joseph Scaliger*, I, 23, and "Quattrocento Humanism," 32-33.

¹⁸ Grafton, *Joseph Scaliger*, I, 23-27, and "Quattrocento Humanism," 32-34; and D'Amico, *Beatus Rhenanus*, 24.

Constantinople, in which book were contained all the laws of the churches, and in which the orders and ranks of the churches were laid out. It was copied out of the book itself in the time of Innocent III.¹⁹

Steuco pinpointed the source of his text for his reader, by citing the testimony which the Latin scribe had prefixed to the document. The copyist had written:

From the book of church laws compiled at the order of the Holy Lord Patriarch of Constantinople Michael and the pious Emperor Lord Manuel, by Theodore Balsamon....²⁰

In addition to notifying the reader of the origins of his manuscript sources, Poliziano also had established the practice of identifying his codices as clearly as possible. Manuscript-based emendation necessitated that other scholars be able to locate and verify the manuscript evidence a critic cited for proposing a textual correction. Moreover, textual retrieval from manuscripts was a collective enterprise. What had escaped or beguiled one scholar looking at a manuscript might not escape or beguile another. Beginning with Poliziano, then, scholars learned to identify the manuscripts they cited and to give their location so that they could be easily consulted.²¹

Steuco carefully followed these strictures. In addition to the above information, he further identified his manuscript by publishing a coda to the text, in which the copyist clearly identified himself as Nicholaus Hydruntinus. This codex, Steuco told his reader, could be found in the library in the monastery of Sant'Antonio in Venice.²²

Steuco's discovery and publication of this Greek manuscript enabled him to point out a glaring error in one of Valla's historical arguments. Valla asserted several times that the Greek emperors had never accepted or approved of the Donation.²³ Yet internal evidence from this Greek text revealed that it had been produced among the Greeks by the late twelfth-century canon

¹⁹ Steuco, *Adversus Lutheranos*, f. 13^r, "Proferam vero decretum ipsius Constantini Graece scriptum, exscriptum ex libro, qui erat in Bibliotheca palatina, Constantinopoli, in quo libro omnia iura ecclesiastica continebantur, et ordines, ac gradus ecclesiarum erant digesti. Descriptum est ex ipso libro tempore Innocentii Tertii...."

²⁰ *Ibid.*, "Εκ του νομοκανονος της βιβλου, της συνοφισθειας εκ προτροπης του μακαριωτα του πατριαρχου κωνσταντινουπολεως κυριε μιχαηλ, και του θεοσεβους βασιλεως κυριου μανουηλ, παρα του θεοδωρου του βαλσαμων. Hoc est. Ex libro iurium ecclesiasticorum, conflato ex iussu beatissimi Patriarchae Constantinopolitani domini Michael, et Pii Imperatoris domini Manuelis, a Theodoro Balsamensi...."

²¹ Grafton, *Joseph Scaliger*, I, 14, 23-29; *idem*, "Quattrocento Humanism," 32-34.

²² Steuco, *Adversus Lutheranos*, f. 14^{r-v}, "Τελος της διαθηκης και διαταξεως του μεγαλου και εν αγιοις κωνσταντινου, ητις εγγραφη παρα νικολαου του υδρουντινου, εν τω μεγαλω παλατιω εν κωνσταντινου πολει απο της βιβλου ως προειρηται."

²³ Valla, *De Constantini donatione*, 21, 42.

lawyer Theodore Balsamon.²⁴ As Balsamon's commentary on the text made clear, he had accepted the Donation as authentic and reproduced a Greek version of the document at Title 8, Chapter 1 of his annotations on the *Nomocanon*. He had revised and annotated this great, authoritative collection of Greek canon and imperial law under direct order from the Byzantine Emperor Manuel I Comnenos (1143-80).²⁵

Both in his *Adversus Lutheranos* and in his *Contra Laurentium Vallam* Steuco seized upon the evidence offered by his newly discovered Greek manuscript as proof that the Greeks had accepted and long venerated the document. Armed with the evidence of the Grimani codex, Steuco tore into Valla's scholarly methodology in his *Contra Laurentium Vallam*:

... it is clear what sort of faith the Greeks had in the decree or edict of Constantine. They did not despise it, but approved it and embraced it. They did not believe, as that grammarian, ignorant of the ancient and more recondite literature believed, that it was false.²⁶

Steuco's charge that Valla was a simple "grammarian" emphasized the methodological weakness of the Vallian *ars rhetorica*. Relying upon philological and grammatical analysis, Valla failed to use the best manuscript sources when examining the text. This in turn led him to ignore the fact that the Greeks...certainly no friends of the papacy...harbored no questions concerning the authenticity of the Donation, and had for centuries accepted it.

Steuco also used Balsamon's text in his *Adversus Lutheranos* to restore a sizable lacuna in Gratian's text that had been overlooked by Valla. In doing so, he sharply criticized another facet of Valla's critical methodology...his reliance upon enthymeme or rhetoric that sought to persuade through induction and examples.²⁷

²⁴ On the Greek canon lawyer and theologian Theodore Balsamon (1140-95), see Josef Hafer and Karl Rahner, *Lexikon für Theologie und Kirche*, 11 vols. (Freiburg, 1957-67), X, 5; and A. Gaudenzi, "Il Costituto di Costantino," *Bullettino dell' Istituto storico italiano*, 39 (1919), 68-78.

²⁵ Nicholas Hydruntinus's introductory note also emphasized that the emperor Manuel I and the Patriarch of Constantinople, Michael Cerulario (1169-77), had requested Balsamon write his annotations on the *Nomocanon*. On Nicholas Hydruntinus see Vecce, "Antonio Galateo," 357-58. For the *Nomocanon* see K. Krumbacher and A. Ehrhard, *Geschichte der Byzantinischen Literatur*, 2 vols. (New York, 1958), II, 607; and the *Lexikon für Theologie und Kirche*, VII, 1024. The text of Balsamon's annotations on title 8, chapter 1 of the *Nomocanon* and his text of the Donation of Constantine are in Migne, PG, CIV, 1078-83.

²⁶ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 226^r, "His clarum est quam fidem habuerint Graeci decreto, sive edicto Constantini. Non contempserunt; sed approbaverunt, amplexi sunt; non crediderunt, quemadmodum vetustarum, reconditarumque litterarum imperitus Grammaticus, esse fabulosum."

²⁷ On argument by enthymeme see de Caprio, "Retorica e ideologia," 46-50; Ginzburg in *La Donation de Constantin*, xi, xv-xx; and Camporeale, *Lorenzo Valla*, 40-46.

Valla drew this method of argumentation from book five of Quintilian's *Institutio oratoria*. Here Quintilian detailed how the orator could argue against the plausibility of an action by showing how the nature of the individual or the time and place involved were incongruous with the presumed action. This of course was an "artificial" proof, and its goal was to persuade by inference rather than convince from dialectical or deductive reasoning.

Enthymeme and rhetorical induction were at the center of a lengthy oration that Valla presented at the opening of the probative section of his treatise.²⁸ Here his goal was to persuade his audience that the actions attributed to Constantine were neither plausible nor credible. He did this by arguing that by nature, rulers and princes did everything in their power to gain and enlarge their territory. Hence to alienate lands or power as Constantine supposedly did in the Donation was incongruous with the nature of rulers. Valla also argued that such largesse on the part of the emperor ran directly counter to historical conditions and the ideology of the fourth-century empire.²⁹

In his *Adversus Lutheranos* Steuco confronted Valla's enthymeme by pointing out that Valla's reliance upon rhetoric was bad methodology that led to erroneous conclusions.³⁰ Toward the beginning of the decree, Constantine gave power, glory and authority to the successors of St. Peter and elevated the Roman see above the other four patriarchates.³¹ In Balsamon's Greek text this action was followed by a declaration of Constantine's esteem for Rome as the spiritual head of the church. "Indeed it is just," the emperor said, "that there the sacred law shall have its head and origin, where the Holy Lawgiver our Savior Jesus Christ ordered blessed Peter to establish his seat...." The Roman people, Constantine continued, shall now bow their heads in obedience to Rome, a city sanctified by the martyrdoms of both Peter and Paul.³²

This passage, found in the oldest texts of the Donation, was lacking in Gratian's *Decretum*, and hence unknown to Valla.³³ Supplying the passage from Balsamon's recension, Steuco countered Valla's enthymeme by articulating one of his own. The emperor's remarks, he said, clearly revealed why he displayed such piety and deep veneration toward St. Peter and his successors. Constantine recognized that the See of Rome had been established by Christ himself, and hence had preeminence in spiritual and ecclesiastical matters. For this reason, Steuco explained, the emperor understood that it

²⁸ Valla, *De Constantini donatione*, 62-85.

²⁹ See Camporeale, "Valla e il *De falso credita donatione*," 15-18.

³⁰ Steuco, *Adversus Lutheranos*, f. 13^v.

³¹ Cf. *Constitutum Constantini*, ll. 165-77.

³² For Balsamon's text, see Steuco, *Adversus Lutheranos*, ff. 13^{r-v}.

³³ See *Constitutum Constantini*, ll. 178-87; cf. Gratian, *Corpus iuris civilis*, 343, where the text is lacking.

would be unseemly if the imperial power remained in Rome where it would come into conflict with the supreme spiritual power. Hence, he concluded, Constantine gave his Western lands and *imperium* to Pope Sylvester, and withdrew from Rome.³⁴

Steuco was wrong, of course, in arguing that Balsamon's text supplied the historical motivation that could logically account for Constantine's largesse to Pope Sylvester, but two aspects of this confrontation are worth noting. First, as a humanist, he did not object to Valla's use of Quintilian's rhetoric as a legitimate form of argumentation in the *De Constantine donatione*. Indeed, he countered with a rhetorical argument of his own.

Secondly, what he did object to, and the point he emphasized, was that rhetoric alone was not a sufficient critical tool in textual emendation. What was at work here was a conflict between methodologies in scholarship. Valla's reliance upon Quintilian's *ars rhetorica* led him to ignore an important lacuna in the text he used. To prevent this type of error, Steuco believed, manuscript-based *emendatio* must precede any other scholarly procedures such as the annotating of the text, or the evaluation of a text's authenticity. To do otherwise exposed the textual critic to the potentially embarrassing situation of annotating a corrupted word or passage or drawing mistaken conclusions about a text's value. This was precisely, Steuco felt, what had happened to Valla.

Steuco cautiously refrained in his *Adversus Lutheranos* from an exhaustive critique of Valla's work. In his *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, however, he set about systematically exposing the shortcomings of the *ars critica* Valla employed in his treatise.

What enabled him to undertake this ambitious scholarly task was his discovery in the Vatican library of three additional Greek manuscripts and one Latin codex containing recensions of the Donation. The textual traditions represented by these manuscripts diverged significantly from that preserved in Gratian's Latin text.³⁵ A collation of these newly uncovered manuscripts together with Balsamon's text provided Steuco with the manuscript evidence he needed to propose numerous corrections to Gratian's Latin text. Based upon this emended reading, he challenged a number of Valla's historical, grammatical, and philological attacks on the Donation.

Several times, for instance, Steuco pointed out that the words which Valla criticized were not found in his recently discovered manuscripts. An example of this occurs in the opening line of the *Donatio*. In announcing his

³⁴ Steuco, *Adversus Lutheranos*, f. 13^v; see also the *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 212^r.

³⁵ On these manuscripts see Gaudenzi, "Costituto di Costantino," *passim*; Enzo Petrucci, "I rapporti tra le redazioni latine e greche del Costituto di Costantino," *Bullettino dell'Istituto storico italiano per il medio evo*, 74 (1962), 45-160; and Fuhrmann's introductory remarks to his edition of the *Constitutum Constantini*, 22-24 and 38-41.

decree, Constantine said that he had consulted “with all the people subject to the power of the Roman church.”

Utile iudicavimus una ... cum cuncto populo imperio Romanae ecclesiae subiacenti....³⁶

Valla raged against this phrase, since it presumed the impossible, namely, that all the people already subject to the church had been consulted in the matter of the Donation. Or, Valla queried, if *populo* referred to the Roman people, how was it that they were already subject to the pope, before Constantine had passed on the *imperium*?³⁷

Steuco correctly argued that here Valla was attacking a corruption in his copy of Gratian’s text. The words *Romanae ecclesiae*, he stated, did not appear in the ancient manuscripts. The true text should read “with all the people subject to the Roman *Imperium*.” “Read the Greek,” Steuco said,

“τω της ρωμαικης βασιλειας μεγαλοτητι υποκειμενω λαω,” or “with the people who are subject to the majesty of the Roman power.” Likewise another manuscript reads,

“και τω δημω τη δοξη ρωμαικης βασιλειας υπεικοντι ,” or “And with the people who are subject to the glory of the Roman power.”³⁸

Steuco also engaged in textual *emendatio* of another kind, aimed at undermining Valla’s criticism by showing his ignorance of major problems within the textual tradition of the *Donatio*. As part of his endowment to the papacy and the church, Constantine bequeathed the lands of Judea, Greece, Asia, Thrace, Africa and Italy to Pope Sylvester. He instructed that the revenues from these lands be used to maintain a perpetual supply of lamps for the churches of Saints Peter and Paul in Rome.³⁹

Valla attacked this passage as anachronistic and unhistorical by pointing out the unlikelihood that any churches dedicated to these saints existed in Rome prior to the emperor’s conversion to Christianity. If such churches did exist, he reasoned, they would have been small shrines or private chapels. They certainly would not have been of such magnitude as to require vast

³⁶ Valla, *De Constantini donatione*, 102.

³⁷ *Ibid.*, 104-5.

³⁸ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 216^v, “Lege Graeca, τω της ρωμαικης βασιλειας μεγαλοτητι υποκειμενω λαω . Populo, qui Romani Imperii maiestati subiacet. Aliud item exemplar, και τω δημω τη δοξη ρωμαικης βασιλειας υπεικοντι . Et populo, qui gloriae Romani Imperii subiacet.” Cf. *Constitutum Constantini*, l. 159, “cuncto populo Romano, gloriae imperii nostri subiacenti.” See also his arguments at f. 219^{r-v}, where he restores *excubitorum* in place of the corrupt *concubitorum* which Valla had attacked.

³⁹ *Constitutum Constantini*, ll. 196-208.

numbers of lamps, and hence the donation of huge tracts of lands for their upkeep.⁴⁰

A collation of his manuscripts revealed to Steuco that this entire passage was problematic. He wrote:

To begin with, it is worthwhile to note that in the ancient Greek manuscripts (indeed while these things were being written the Palatine library furnished us with four codices to keep before our eyes) the entire passage cited above does not exist; and we are led to suspect that this edict was corrupted in many places because it was repeatedly transcribed, for the most part a common misfortune of books. Thus in the older manuscripts this passage does not exist, perhaps it has been interpolated from other books. In the two ancient Greek codices there is nothing about the lamps, about Africa, Asia, the northern lands, or the endowments. However, Lorenzo's accusations find no support in the other two manuscripts where the passages do exist. For [here] the highest emperor first recorded that he himself had built the churches of the apostles and endowed them...: *For we built churches both to the blessed Peter and to Paul, the first apostles, which were decorated with silver and gold, and were luxurious.*⁴¹

These remarks not only point out a difficulty in the text unknown to Valla, they also reveal a sophisticated attempt by Steuco to evaluate the worth of his manuscript evidence and to use it critically to solve textual problems. He clearly identified two manuscripts which he felt were of the greatest textual authority. One of these two manuscripts contained Balsamon's Greek text. Steuco held this manuscript in high regard, believing its origins to date far earlier than Balsamon's twelfth-century copy.⁴² He vari-

⁴⁰ Valla, *De Constantini donatione*, 110-12.

⁴¹ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, ff. 217^v-218^r, "Primum scire operae pretium in antiquis exemplaribus Graecis (quatuor autem ante oculos Palatina Bibliotheca suggererat, cum haec scriberentur) non haberi totam superius propositam periodon: ac suspicari cogimur, multis in locis corruptum fuisse hoc edictum propter crebras transcriptiones, librorum communis fere calamitas. Igitur in vetustioribus exemplaribus ea particula non extat, forsitan interiecta ex aliis libris. In duobus vetustis codicibus Graecis nihil habetur, de luminibus, de Aphrica, et Asia, Septentrione, de praediis possessionum. In aliis autem duobus exemplaribus, ubi haec habentur, nullus patet locus Laurentianae calumniae. Nam summus Imperator primum memorat, ut ipse Apostolorum templa ex aedificaverit, eaque ditaverit.... ωκοδομησαμην δε εκκλησιας, και τοις μακαριοις Πετρω και Παυλω τοις πρωτοις αποστολοις ας αργυρω και χρυσω διαπρεπεις, και αβρας απεφημαμεν."

⁴² I have not succeeded in locating the manuscript of Balsamon's text which Steuco used while in Venice. However, the Vatican library preserves several manuscripts containing Balsamon's Greek text from which Steuco could have worked while composing the *Contra Laurentium Vallam*. (Vat. gr. 844, ff. 30^r-31^v; Regina gr. 51, ff. 48^r-50^r; Vat. gr.

ously referred to it as the “codex pervetustus Graecus” and the “Graecum exemplar vetustum.”⁴³

The second codex whose evidence he held in great esteem closely paralleled Balsamon’s text in both vocabulary and recension. Unbeknownst to Steuco, this text shared the same origins as Balsamon’s Greek text...a Latin text of the Donation which Pope Leo IX sent to Constantinople in 1053.⁴⁴ Each was an independent translation of Leo IX’s Latin recension of the Donation. Together these two manuscripts represented for Steuco the “emendatis exemplaribus” and “vetustioribus exemplaribus.”⁴⁵ Since neither of these Greek texts preserved the passage Valla attacked, Steuco argued that the text had been interpolated.

Steuco’s two remaining manuscripts contained the disputed passage, but he rejected their authority in favor of the evidence provided by Balsamon’s text and its close companion. These second two manuscripts date from the late fourteenth and early fifteenth centuries, and contained Greek translations of the Donation text as it existed in the Pseudo-Isidorean decretals.⁴⁶ Following the ninth-century Latin recension of the Pseudo-Isidorean text, these two manuscripts presented a reading which differed in a number of places from that preserved in the later texts of Balsamon and Gratian.⁴⁷ Steuco was unaware of the origins of these two Greek manuscripts. He believed they represented a later, corrupted form of the Donation. What he correctly perceived, however, was that these fourteenth-century manuscripts revealed a further problem with the text at this point.

1276, ff. 96^r-98^v; and Vat. gr. 1416, f. 120^r-24^v). See Petrucci, “Redazioni latine e greche,” 57-60; and Giovanni Mercati, *Notizie di Procoro e Demetrio Cidone Manuele Caleca e Teodoro Meliteniota, Studi e testi*, LVI (Vatican City, 1931), 162-63.

⁴³ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, ff. 219^r, 217^r.

⁴⁴ See Petrucci, “Redazioni latine e greche,” 132-51; and Gaudenzi, “Costituto di Costantino,” 36-37, who identify the following Vatican manuscripts containing this version of the Donation: Vat. gr. 81, ff. 1^r-2^r; Vat. gr. 606, ff. 302^r-304^r; Vat gr. 1115, ff. 1^r-2^r, all dating from the late fourteenth century. Of these three manuscripts, Steuco apparently knew one. Gaudenzi, “Costituto di Costantino,” 87-108, has produced a copy of this Greek text.

⁴⁵ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, ff. 217^v, 218^r.

⁴⁶ Petrucci, “Redazioni latine e greche,” 151, argues that the author of this Greek translation was the fourteenth century Byzantine scholar Demetrio Cidone (d. 1396), who made his translation in Italy sometime around 1369. On Cidone, see Mercati, *Demetrio Cidone*, 106-24. Petrucci, “Redazioni latine e greche,” 56-57 and 151-60; Gaudenzi, “Costituto di Costantino,” 36-37; and Mercati, *Demetrio Cidone*, 162-63, identify the following codices in the Vatican which contain this version of the text: Vat. gr. 1102, ff. 77^r-82^v; Vat. gr. 614, ff. 76^r-79^v; Vat gr. 778, ff. 567^r-75^v; Vat gr. 789, ff. 185^r-92^r; Vat gr. 973, ff. 39^r-48^v; Ottob. gr. 309, ff. 11^r-18^v. A copy of this Greek text can be found in Gaudenzi, “Costituto di Costantino,” 108-12.

⁴⁷ For the Pseudo-Isidorean text see Fuhrmann, *Einfluss und Verbreitung*, 354-89; and Schafer Williams, “The Oldest Text of the *Constitutum Constantini*,” *Traditio*, 20 (1964), 448-61.

While both manuscripts contained the passage dealing with the lamps which Valla had criticized in Gratian, they also preserved a further text found neither in Gratian, nor in what Steuco believed were his two best manuscripts. This is the Greek text given in the quotation above, in which the emperor explained how he had constructed the churches of Saints Peter and Paul and richly decorated them. This text, Steuco noted, answered Valla's criticism that no large churches existed in Rome when the Donation was made. Despite the potential this variant text offered for refuting Valla, Steuco ultimately rejected it. It was not found in what he perceived to be his most authoritative manuscripts, and he judged it a later addition.⁴⁸

Steuco's handling of these four manuscripts closely followed the codicological method which Angelo Poliziano had established.⁴⁹ The Florentine humanist taught scholars to identify manuscript traditions and to group manuscripts according to families, and this is precisely what Steuco did here. He clearly recognized two families of manuscripts, the first dominated by Balsamon's text, which he regarded as an archetype or parent manuscript. The second family was comprised of the two late fourteenth- and early fifteenth-century manuscripts. Steuco judged these manuscripts to be later derivatives from the textual tradition represented by the manuscripts of the first family. In a manner typical of Poliziano, he attributed their "corruption" to scribal error.

What is particularly noteworthy is Steuco's effort to weigh textual evidence critically rather than simply cite the texts most favorable to his emendation. These procedures were aimed at establishing the *vera lectio* of the text, but they had an obvious polemical edge as well: to emphasize how ill-equipped the Vallian *ars rhetorica* was to deal with problems of codicology and conflicting manuscript authority. Steuco's work showed once again that sixteenth-century textual scholarship had moved far beyond the philological and grammatical methodology employed by Valla.⁵⁰

The strength of Valla's scholarly inquiry in his treatise was, of course, grammatical and philological inquiry. Acutely aware that usage and style were closely linked to a specific historical era, Valla argued that many of the words and grammatical structures which appeared in the text did not reflect the writing of Constantine's age. He levelled such a charge at the following passage, ostensibly from the mouth of Constantine: "... the pontiff ... shall be more exalted than and prince to all the priests of the entire world

⁴⁸ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 218r, "... ea periodus in emendatis exemplaribus non habetur ... Mihi quidem maxime probatur, ut periodus de praediis, et luminibus sit interiecta."

⁴⁹ This discussion is based on Grafton, *Joseph Scaliger*, I, 25-27, and "Quattrocento Humanism," 35-42; and D'Amico, *Beatus Rhenanus*, 11, 23-24.

⁵⁰ Using *emendatio ope codicum* and codicological procedures, modern textual scholarship has produced a critical edition of the Donation text. See Fuhrmann's introductory remarks to the *Constitutum Constantini*, 7-47.

(... *pontifex ... celsior et princeps cunctis sacerdotibus et totius mundi existat ...*).⁵¹

This was a barbarous turn of phrase, Valla claimed, because the forger had followed the nominative *princeps* with the dative form *sacerdotibus* instead of the genitive form *sacerdotum* that was grammatically correct.⁵² Steuco countered this criticism by arguing that Valla's grammatical censure was directed at a corrupted text. The best manuscript, Balsamon's recension, offered a variant reading which contained no such solecism:

And he who through the succeeding ages will be Roman Bishop
οφειλει ειναι ενδοξος και υψηλοτερος παρα παντας τοις ιερείς
του κοσμου, or "it is fitting that he be superior to all the priests of
the world."

Steuco pointed out that the word *princeps* which took the genitive, did not appear in Balsamon's text, being replaced by the words "Roman Bishop":

"Prince," as you see, does not occur in this place, there is no barbarism in speech, nor has the dative case been used in place of the genitive.⁵³

In another instance, Valla attacked the following declaration of the emperor Constantine: "choosing the same prince of the apostles, or his vicars, to be firm patrons for us before God (*eligentes nobis ipsum principem apostolorum, vel eius vicarios, firmos apud Deum esse patronos*)."⁵⁴ Deriding the Latin of this speech, Valla appealed to the fourth-century author Lactantius, asking, "Did the scribes of the Caesars speak in this fashion in your age, or even their grooms?" Especially grating to Valla was the phrase *firmos patronos*, because it lacked the refinement of speech and meaning appropriate to the language of Constantine's era. "And that *firmos patronos*," he scoffed, "how truly elegant it is!"⁵⁵ Steuco, however, again cited a variant in Balsamon's Greek text to demonstrate the questionable nature of Valla's methodology and ensuing criticism:

⁵¹ *Constitutum Constantini*, ll. 175-76.

⁵² Valla, *De Constantini donatione*, 107.

⁵³ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 217r, "Ac primum non est, ut tu legisti, 'Celsior et Princeps cunctis sacerdotibus,' sed Graecum exemplar vetustum habet, 'Atque eum qui per aetates succedentes futurus est Romanus Episcopus οφειλει ειναι ενδοξος και υψηλοτερος παρα παντας τοις ιερείς του κοσμου : decet esse insignem, omnibusque mundi sacerdotibus superiorem.' 'Princeps,' ut vides, hoc loco nusquam est, nulla in sermone barbaries, neque pro casu gignendi, positus est casus dandi."

⁵⁴ *Constitutum Constantini*, ll. 164-65.

⁵⁵ Valla, *De Constantini donatione*, 105-7. On Valla's understanding of the term "elegance," see Marsh, "Grammar, Method, and Polemic," 101, and De Caprio, "Rhetorica e ideologia," 38-39.

In the Greek codex he could have noted a variant. “And we desire,” he [Constantine] said, “the prince himself or the *coryphaeus* of the apostles και τους διαδοχους αυτου ...and his successors from his person...πρωτους προς τον θεον πατερας ειναι..to be the first fathers before God.”⁵⁶

Balsamon’s text, Steuco pointed out, lacked the offending phrase *firmos patronos*. Instead it had *primos patres*, by which, he explained, Constantine meant that the successors of Peter were to hold the chief place before God in matters of religion and piety.

The variant readings preserved in his manuscript enabled Steuco to question many of the criticisms Valla raised concerning the language of the Donation. But on a number of occasions he found that his manuscripts had the same word (or a Greek equivalent) that Valla had censured as anachronistic or ill fitting with the Latin of Constantine’s time. When this happened, he advanced the argument that Valla’s philological criticisms were misdirected, because his manuscripts preserved the word in question.

A good example of this process occurs in the scholarly exchange which took place over the following text. Here Constantine bequeathed to Pope Sylvester many of the imperial trappings with which he himself was adorned:

Beato Silvestro ... contradimus ... diademam, videlicet coronam capitis nostri, simulque phrygium, nec non et superhumerales, videlicet lorum, qui imperiale circumdare assolet collum....⁵⁷

Valla attacked the Latin of this passage, stating that the word *phrygium* (tiara) was never used in Latin. It was not at all clear, he stated, what the term even meant. He also criticized the word *superhumerales* (shoulder-band), which the forger had equated (*videlicet*) with *lorum* (strap). Valla explained that *lorum* was a strap made out of leather...a harness. Certainly this was not worn around the Emperor’s neck! On the other hand, if the forger intended the *lorum* to be worked in gold, this was an insult as well, since golden straps (*aurea lora*) only referred to gilded harnesses used on animals. Such barbarisms of speech and stupidity of language, Valla observed, betrayed the document as a lie.⁵⁸

⁵⁶ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 216^v, “In codice Graeco poterat varietatem subnotare. ‘Et volumus,’ inquit, ‘ipsum principem, aut coryphaeum apostolorum και τους διαδοχους αυτου...Successoresque eius ex persona eius...πρωτους προς τον θεον πατερας ειναι...primos apud Deum esse patres.’ Vides, ut non habeat, ‘Firmos apud Deum esse Patronos,’ sed ‘primos apud Deum esse patres.’ ”

⁵⁷ *Constitutum Constantini*, ll. 216-22.

⁵⁸ Valla, *De Constantini donatione*, 114, 117-18.

Steuco countered Valla's philological criticisms of the word *phrygium* by arguing that it was a borrowing from the Greek. The ancient Phrygians, he correctly pointed out, were known for their skilled embroidery in gold and gems.⁵⁹ Hence he reasoned that among the Greeks the term *phrygium* came to designate a silk headcovering worked in gold and gems. He then cited the passage as it appeared in one of his fourteenth-century manuscripts, which gave a further clue as to the meaning of the term *phrygium*:

Indeed we give ... the *diadem*, namely the crown of our head ομοιος δε και το φρυγιον τουτεστι την καλυπτραν η την μιτραν, αλλα και το επωμιον, ηγουν το λωρον οπερ ειωθε τον βασιλειον περικυκλουν αυχινα ... And likewise, he said, the *phrygium*, namely the cover of the head, or mitre. And the *superhumale*, namely the *lorum*, which is accustomed to go round the neck of the emperor.⁶⁰

Steuco, observing that this Greek text equated the term *phrygium* with *mitra*, said that perhaps a *mitra* or turban was called a *phrygium*, because *mitrae* were characteristic of the Phrygians.⁶¹ He backed up this manuscript authority by citing from a Latin text of the Donation which he had discovered in a manuscript in the Vatican library. This codex, which he judged "sufficiently old," gave a parallel reading that also equated *phrygium* with *mitra*: "Pileum, vel mitram, vel phrygium, necnon et superhumale, videlicet lorum." This manuscript evidence, Steuco argued, weighed against Valla's contentions that the term *phrygium* was obscure, or that it was inappropriate in a document from Constantine's age.⁶²

He next turned to Valla's assertions that the author of the Donation had no idea what the words *lorum* and *superhumale* meant, because they were used synonymously in Gratian's text. Referring to the Greek and Latin texts cited above, Steuco countered that it was common practice for Greek and Latin authors to use the names interchangeably in their own language.⁶³ To substantiate his point further, he quoted Balsamon's version of the text in question, which also paired *lorum* with *superhumale*.⁶⁴ The wealth of

⁵⁹ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 218^v.

⁶⁰ *Ibid.*, "Tradimus, inquit, etiam diadema, nempe coronam capitis nostri ομοιος δε και το φρυγιον τουτεστι την καλυπτραν η την μιτραν, αλλα και το επωμιον, ηγουν το λωρον οπερ ειωθε τον βασιλειον περικυκλουν αυχινα . Similiter inquit et phrygium, nempe tegmen capitis, sive mitram, Atque superhumale, nempe Lorum, quod Imperatoris collum solet obnubere."

⁶¹ *Ibid.*

⁶² *Ibid.*, Steuco is citing from Codex Vat. lat. 630, ff. 74^r-76^r, which contained the text of the Donation as it appeared in the Pseudo-Isidorean recension. On this manuscript, see Williams, "Oldest Text," 448-51; and Fuhrmann in *Constitutum Constantini*, 24, 87.

⁶³ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 218^v.

⁶⁴ *Ibid.*, "και το λωρον το ωμοφοριον."

manuscript evidence at his disposal led Steuco to conclude that Valla's philological criticisms of this passage were ill founded as well. "Thus since these things are in the ancient Greek and Latin manuscripts," he asked, "why are they scoffed at by Lorenzo?"⁶⁵

Steuco's philological conclusions were wrong, of course, because he believed his texts to be substantially older than they actually were. These manuscripts could not be used as authoritative philological evidence to prove that the style and usage of the language in the Latin text dated from Constantine's era. Nevertheless, it is clear that behind Steuco's attempts to link the language of the text to the fourth century lay a carefully considered philological analysis which closely analyzed words in a cultural and historical context.

A brief look at Steuco's philological method here will be useful, because it represents the best scholarly procedures used among early sixteenth-century textual scholars. Steuco drew upon a wealth of collateral historical documents, literary evidence and his own Greek manuscripts to establish a time and place appropriate to the literary style of the text. Thus philological inquiry, it is important to note, moved into the realm of higher criticism as well.

This aspect of Steuco's scholarship is significant because it challenged Valla where he had been most effective in his criticism of the edict. Steuco's own philological and historical inquiry was predicated upon his knowledge that the Donation had a vigorous and centuries old textual tradition among the Greeks. Armed with this information, he argued (in some cases quite correctly) that Valla's philological analysis was decidedly unhistorical and insensitive to the relationship between culture and language.

A characteristic of sixteenth-century textual scholarship was the use of collateral historical sources to help date and annotate manuscripts.⁶⁶ Steuco showed himself sensitive to this procedure, as he sought to establish the circumstances and period in which the document was written. Consultation of the Decrees of the Council of Nicea (325) revealed that this council and the Donation shared a number of similar ideas on doctrine and ecclesiology. Steuco correctly pointed out, for example, that Constantine's edict established the hierarchy among the ancient patriarchal sees of Rome, Constantinople, Alexandria, Jerusalem, and Antioch. In the Donation Constantine also decreed that Rome was superior to the other patriarchates.⁶⁷

This ranking of ecclesiastical authority also occurred, he noted, at the Council of Nicea, with Rome again recognized as the supreme ecclesiastical authority. This and other collateral evidence found in the decrees of the

⁶⁵ *Ibid.*, "Cum sint igitur haec in antiquis Graecis ac Latinis exemplaribus, cur iridentur a Laurentio?"

⁶⁶ For fine examples of sixteenth-century humanists who employed this technique see D'Amico, *Beatus Rhenanus, passim*, and Bentley, *Humanists and Holy Writ*, 112-93.

⁶⁷ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 217^v; cf. *Constitutum Constantini*, ll. 171-77.

council consequently led him to assert that the Donation was written down either shortly before or after the council took place.⁶⁸

A Nicene-era composition had an enormous attraction for Steuco because it allowed him to make historical and philological sense out of the textual evidence. As he pointed out, this meant that a number of years had elapsed from the time when Constantine had orally made his donation to Pope Sylvester until the time when he actually had it written down. A Nicene time-frame thus meant that the text was composed after Constantine left Rome and moved the imperial court to Byzantium. The hypothesis of a Byzantine origin of the text enabled Steuco to refute a number of the arguments in which Valla had pointed out ostensible anachronisms in the decree.⁶⁹

Equally important, a close association of the Donation with the Council of Nicea and the Byzantine court allowed Steuco to contest Valla's assertion that anachronistic words, a barbarous style, and phrases reeking of ecclesiastical Latin betrayed the decree as a forgery.⁷⁰ Steuco countered Valla's indictment of the Donation's language by arguing that the style revealed that it had indeed been composed by a clergyman, probably a bishop. But, he hastened to add, this bishop worked at the behest of the emperor himself. It was only natural, he pointed out, that such a man "would speak more in a Christian fashion and according to sacred scripture, than in a Roman manner." Most likely, he continued, this bishop was a Greek who was limited somewhat in his command of Latin. Such a writer would leave his mark on the text of the decree; and this, Steuco argued, helped explain the literary style found in the text.⁷¹ He also pointed out that the premise of a Greek author of the text would explain the many borrowings from the Greek language scattered throughout the text.⁷²

Steuco also took issue with Valla's contention that the degenerate, unclassical language of the text could not have come from Constantine's age. In so doing, he directly challenged Valla's philological methodology. Time

⁶⁸ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 217^r, "Est igitur vera ratio, haec post aliquot annos, et forsan sub tempora concilii Niceni fuisse digesta. In quo concilio est dispositio cathedrarum Constantinopolitanae, Alexandrinae. Daturque primatus Romanae sedi. Ad eum canonem concilii Niceni directa est confessio, et donatio, sive ante concilium, sive aliquanto post...." See also f. 216^v. Steuco here is referring to Canon 6 of the Council of Nicea, which by the time of the Council of Constantinople (381) had begun to be understood as granting primacy to Rome. See on this Karl Hefele, *Histoire des conciles*, 11 vols. (Paris, 1907-49), I, 552-69.

⁶⁹ Valla for instance, *De Constantini donatione*, 108-9, had pointed out that the Donation referred to the city and patriarchate of Constantinople, before the city had been founded. Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 217^r, countered Valla's objections by arguing for a Nicene era decree.

⁷⁰ Valla, *De Constantini donatione*, 126-27, writes, "Quid, illa loquendi barbaries nonne testatur non seculo Constantini, sed posteriori cantilenam hanc esse confictam?" For his remarks on ecclesiastical Latin, see 118, 126, 134.

⁷¹ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 216^v.

⁷² See his remarks at *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 216^v, on the word *satrap*, which Valla had attacked in the *De Constantini donatione*, 103.

and again Valla had compared the Latin style and usage in the Donation with that found in the fourth-century writer Lactantius, who, of course, was one of the best prose stylists of the early Christian era, having modeled his own literary style on that of Cicero. Moreover, Valla on several occasions had cited the writings of Cicero and Sallust, two of the foremost writers of the late Republic, as arbiters of proper style and usage for the Latin of the text.⁷³ Steuco contended that Valla was wrong to look for classical Latin style in the time of Constantine:

Who could have any doubt that the speech in the time of Constantine was not pure Roman, or that the princes of that time were no longer accustomed to speak as had the earlier Romans Caesar, Pompey and the Senate?⁷⁴

To support his point, Steuco cited epigraphic evidence from the Arch of Constantine where the inscription read, “Divinitatis instinctu sumpsisse Constantinum arma contra Maxentium.” Steuco observed that this was not classical Latin:

... never among the ancient Romans do you read *Divinitas* for *Deus*, they would have said *instinctu Dei*, or *Deorum*, not [speaking], in accordance with the the Greek custom, of το θειον.⁷⁵

In addition to epigraphic evidence, Steuco referred to a number of literary texts in support of his contention that the Latin of the fourth century was indeed corrupt. Read the letters of the emperors in the Councils of Nicea, Ephesus, and Chalcedon, he advised his reader, and note “how greatly they deviate from the ancient phrases of the Romans.”⁷⁶ The text of the Donation, he argued, “is an indication of the time in which the edict was written, because it is redolent of the speech of an age now degenerating into barbarousness.”⁷⁷

⁷³ For Lactantius, see Valla, *De Constantini donatione*, 106; for Cicero, 104 and 117; for Sallust 104; and for references to the Republican Senate, 103.

⁷⁴ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 216^v.

⁷⁵ *Ibid.* Steuco’s use of epigraphical evidence here in textual emendation places him in the mainstream of textual and epigraphical studies in mid-sixteenth-century Rome. For epigraphy and antiquarian studies in general at Rome during this period see Richard Cooper, “Epigraphical Research in Rome in the Mid-Sixteenth Century: The papers of Antonio Agustin and Jean Matal,” *Antonio Agustin Between Renaissance and Counter-Reformation*, ed. Michael Crawford (London, 1993), 95-111. On the development of epigraphy as a scholarly tool in the Renaissance, see Roberto Weiss, *The Renaissance Discovery of Classical Antiquity* (Oxford, 1969), 145-67. On Poliziano’s use of epigraphy in textual scholarship see Grafton, *Joseph Scaliger*, I, 32.

⁷⁶ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 216^v.

⁷⁷ *Ibid.*, “Non mirum igitur sermonem donationis non esse pure Romanum. Est sermo illius saeculi, potius id indicio sit eo tempore scriptum edictum, quod redoleat sermonem saeculi iam in barbariem degenerantis.”

Steuco urged his reader to go beyond Lactantius and consult the writings of other authors from the period such as the fourth-century Roman historian Ammianus Marcellinus, or Arnobius, Boethius, or Severinus. "This is not the speech," he remarked, "which the Senate spoke in the time of Caesar and Pompey." It was simply wrong of Valla, he concluded, to expect the beauty of Roman speech from that age.⁷⁸

Steuco's close linking of language to culture and a specific historical age betrays the acute mind of a philologist at work. His arguments also emphasize a point too often overlooked in Vallian scholarship, namely, that Valla's philological critique of the decree was not as rigorous as it might have been. Valla all too often judged the language of the Donation against the linguistic style and usage characteristic of the late Roman Republic.⁷⁹

A more fundamental criticism of Valla's scholarship emerges from our examination of Steuco's philological analysis of the decree. For Steuco philology was an important tool that could and must be used in textual criticism, but he did not believe that philological and grammatical analysis alone were sufficient to carry out textual scholarship. Good textual criticism began with the careful collation of manuscripts and the establishment of the *vera lectio* of the text. Philology could certainly aid this process, but it was not the principal critical tool. Rather, it represented one of a series of techniques which the scholar brought to his manuscript analysis.⁸⁰

Steuco carried out his attack on Valla's scholarly methodology using the most advanced procedures of textual criticism known to the early sixteenth century. This meant textual analysis based on *emendatio ope codicum*. For Steuco, Valla's weakness, even in his philological analysis, was his failure to consult the best manuscripts before undertaking his critique of the decree. The study of his Greek manuscripts pushed Steuco to examine the Latin text of the Donation in light of what he believed were older, more authoritative sources. This study enabled him to show that numerous variants and textual problems had to be considered before Valla's criticisms could be taken as final.

Similarly, the Greek texts forced him to reconsider, through philological and historical analysis, the time and place of the edict's composition. This cogency of philological and historical analysis led him to expose a tendency in Valla's earlier philological methodology toward disjunction between language and culture.

In view of recent favorable scholarship concerning Valla as a language philosopher and practitioner of the *ars rhetorica*, it would be comforting,

⁷⁸ *Ibid.*, f. 216'.

⁷⁹ Petrucci, "Redazioni latine e greche," 46, n. 2, is the only author I have seen remark on this.

⁸⁰ See Grafton, "Quattrocento Humanism," 48; and D'Amico, *Beatus Rhenanus*, *passim*.

perhaps, to shrug off Steuco's attacks as interesting but ineffectual. After all, Valla did succeed in exposing the edict as a forgery. But this would miss the point of Steuco's work. His own professed goal was not to demonstrate with absolute certainty the veracity of the Donation. He readily confessed that the edict was of doubtful authenticity.⁸¹ Rather, his goal was to demonstrate the weakness of Valla's arguments by sixteenth-century standards. To the extent that he exposed the methodological shortcomings of the Vallian *ars rhetorica*, he succeeded splendidly.

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⁸¹ Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam*, f. 222^r, writes "Non me quidem velle probare, atque omni ratione contendere, donationem esse veram: sed concessio eam dubiam esse, clariores ac plures extare rationes, quae veram esse probent, quam rationes Laurentii valere ad probandum non esse veram...."